

Exploring Users' Experiences of "Suggested Posts" in Social Media Through the Lens of Social Networking and Interactions

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ABSTRACT

Many social media feeds are incorporated with "Suggested Posts," an AI-infused feature that recommends algorithmically selected posts from accounts that a user does not follow. While such recommendations might increase user engagement with the platforms, there lacks understanding on how such system-driven recommendations influence the primary purpose of social media use: social interactions. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 12 Instagram users to investigate how they perceive the "Suggested Posts" feature in relation to their in-app social interaction practices. Our findings reveal that suggested posts acted as a double-edged sword for communication with their actual friends, acted as an obstacle for digital self-presentation, and acted as an unwanted force that compel users to increase social groups. Based on the findings, we discuss the importance of considering user agency over social interactions in designing user experiences of recommendations provided in social media.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in interaction design.

KEYWORDS

social media, recommender systems, suggested posts, interaction design, social interactions

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1 INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

While designed to support social networking and interactions among users, social media platforms have started to be equipped with recommender systems, providing a feature called "Suggested Posts" (figure 1). This feature proactively recommends posts that are uploaded by accounts that users do not follow based on the user's

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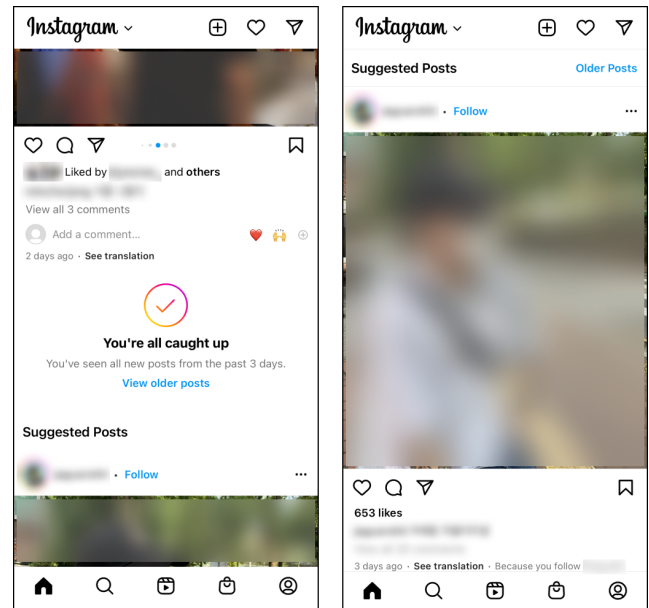


Figure 1: "Suggested Posts" feature on Instagram app Home Feed

activities in the apps, such as who the user follows and what posts the user has liked, saved, or commented on [17, 18, 22]. In the case of Instagram, when users finish scrolling down all the posts from the accounts that they follow, the Home Feed continues by suggesting an endless number of posts.

While suggested posts have enriched social media news feeds, little attention has been directed to how those recommendations might influence the primary activity that occurs on social media platforms, i.e. social interactions among users [12, 13]. For example, if a user's main purpose of using social media is to interact with his or her actual friends, s/he may perceive currently-dominant forms of suggested posts to be unnecessary or intrusive, no matter how interesting those posts are. Nevertheless, most prior studies on recommender systems in social feeds have been conducted from the perspective of algorithmic experience and therefore focused on exploring user experiences in relation to opaque algorithms of AI [2, 6, 7, 15, 21]. An exception is a recent study [11] exploring how users experienced suggested posts that appear in their Instagram news feed, highlighting that the quality of user experiences of such posts is in strong relation to users' social interactional practices.

We continue and extend this line of work, investigating how suggested posts on social media platforms influence users' social

interactions in particular. In this paper, social interaction on social media includes both maintaining and strengthening relationships with actual friends and building relationships with strangers [13]. By conducting interviews with 12 Instagram users, we explored how users perceive suggested posts in the context of social networking and interactions on Instagram, as well as how suggested posts support or hinder such practices. Our findings reveal that suggested posts both facilitated and hindered communication with their actual friends, acted as an obstacle to digital self-presentation, and acted as an unwanted force that compel users to increase their social groups. We end with a discussion on the design implications of these findings, speculating on the importance of user agency over social interactions in designing user experiences of recommender systems on social media platforms.

2 METHODS

We conducted one-on-one semi-structured interviews with social media users, aiming to explore in depth their perceptions and expectations regarding suggested posts appearing in their social media feeds. All the interviews were conducted online via Zoom to ensure safety regarding COVID-19. The study was approved by the Institutional Review Board (KH2021-014).

We recruited a total of 12 participants (Female=7). All participants had been users of Instagram for no less than one year and had frequent encounters with suggested posts in their feeds. We selected Instagram as the representative context of the inquiry, as it is the most widely used social media platform in the country where this study was conducted [20]. All participants were Koreans in their 20s, the age group that most actively uses Instagram [20], with the average age being 23.9 years.

During the interviews, we first asked participants why and how they usually use Instagram as well as other social media, if any. Then, we asked participants what they thought about the basic characteristics of suggested posts. In addition, we asked how users currently perceive and experience suggested posts, such as how they encounter and interact with the posts, what they like or dislike about the posts, and how their interactions with other users are influenced by the posts. Lastly, we asked participants how they perceived the role of suggested posts in social-media-based interactions to be. During the interview, participants were encouraged to access and browse their Instagram feeds if necessary. Each interview lasted about an hour.

All the interviews were recorded with the consent of the participants, and a total of 651 minutes of recorded data were transcribed into text. We obtained a total of 187 quotations separated by semantic units of the text and conducted a thematic analysis [4] on them. The focus of the analysis lied on users' experiences of suggested posts, especially regarding their social interactions on social media. Through iterative coding and discussion, two researchers drew key sub-themes: "promoting communication with friends", "hindering to check friends' posts", "hesitating to react to suggested posts", "worry about appearing own post as the suggested post", "perceiving suggested posts as forcing communication with strangers". As a result, this analysis process surfaced three primary themes on how suggested posts impacted users' social interactions.

3 FINDINGS: IMPACT OF SUGGESTED POSTS ON USERS' SOCIAL INTERACTION

Our findings reveal that participants appreciated suggested posts as they facilitated communication with actual friends. However, suggested posts were also perceived to hinder participants' digital self-presentation and force them to increase social groups, as reported in the following.

3.1 A double-edged sword for communications with actual friends

For most participants, the main purpose of social media use was to communicate with their actual friends, and suggested posts could support this. Eight participants mentioned experiences where they contacted their friends by sharing suggested posts in various ways. For example, when P2 found a suggested post about the news that happened at a restaurant, she shared it with a friend who had actually visited the restaurant with her to initiate small talks. When P4 saw suggested posts of nearby tourist spots, she contacted friends with whom she wanted to go there in order to make travel plans. As these examples illustrate, suggested posts acted as new topics that triggered social interactions among participants and their actual friends, a positive aspect of the "Suggested Post" feature that most participants appreciated.

As such, participants emphasized the auxiliary characteristics of suggested posts, pointing out how current designs could also hinder social interactions. Nine participants mentioned that their news feeds seemed to prioritize suggested posts over the posts uploaded by whom they actually follow, thereby making it difficult to catch up with their actual friends and communicate with them: *"It's a case of the tail wagging the dog. My feed was originally a place to watch friends' stories, but now I have to click 'View Older Posts' to see them. This is kind of an invasion."* (P5) Also, P10 even felt deceived by Instagram after belatedly realizing that the posts she thought to be her friends' posts were actually suggested posts, as those posts were not outwardly clearly distinguishable from their friends' posts. Collectively, some participants appreciated suggested posts as a social lubricant, but some did not as the posts presented themselves in an inappropriate manner.

3.2 An obstacle for self-presentation

On social media platforms, various user activities are exposed to users' followers, which makes them an important place for self-presentation rich with social meaning [5]. We also observed that participants engaged in their self-presentation behaviors on Instagram, and the "Suggested Posts" feature influenced such behaviors of our participants. For example, some participants noted that they avoided reacting to suggested posts, such as pressing "Like", because they were aware that those reactions might be shown to their followers. For example, P6 wanted to comment on a suggested post in order to interact with the user who posted it, but he did not do so as he was afraid his followers might get to see the comment: *"In the sense that I like a certain suggested post to communicate with the account, I can leave a comment of support or thanks, but it feels a little uncomfortable because my acquaintances who follow me can see it."* (P6) Also, P8 mentioned that he had been rarely interacting with

the suggested posts after he belatedly realized that the suggested posts he had liked were shown to his friends.

Participants were also concerned with the fact that one's post might randomly appear as a suggested post in the news feeds of other users. For example, P10 described that she was surprised to find a post by someone she knew as a suggested post, which made her think she might also be shown to others in the same way. Although she kept her account as public so that any Instagram users could see her profile, she was discontented with the fact that she could not prevent her posts from being recommended to other users, thereby losing control over managing her "impression" [9] in Instagram: *"If I post about my personal life and it appears like an advertisement in front of a thousand people I don't know, it can feel bad. It's like I'm being used by Instagram..."* (P11) Collectively, the "Suggested Posts" feature seemed to deprive participants of controllability in their self-presentation behaviors.

3.3 Pressure for unasked-for social networking

Since suggested posts are user-created contents after all, those posts appeared to be a channel that bridges a user with strangers within the social media community. While two participants (P10, P11) welcomed this opportunity and expressed their desire to get to know and network with the unknowns, most of our participants disliked the fact that strangers' posts appeared in their feeds. For example, some participants mentioned that they could accept entertainment-domain content recommendations (e.g., YouTube or Netflix) without reluctance, but they did not welcome suggested posts on social media platforms, as those posts were not intended for entertainment but were perceived to be forcing social networking. For example, P1 believed that the "Suggested Posts" feature forced him to engage in social interactions with strangers: *"I think the intention of launching suggested posts is to encourage active connection by following new people while thinking 'there're also accounts like this.' But just because I have Instagram doesn't mean I need to see everyone on it, so it's kinda bad. It's just like when my mom said, 'you just be his friend,' or 'go and play with him' when I was young. I don't know him."* (P1) Also, some participants perceived that interaction with a suggested post meant a sudden initiator of interaction with the post's owner, which made them hesitate to enjoy the feature. For example, P9 criticized the one-way matching system of the "Suggested Posts" feature (i.e. the fact that someone's post is recommended in my feed does not guarantee that my post is also recommended in that user's feed). This made her reluctant to interact with a suggested post, as she thought simply pressing "Like" might initiate interaction that neither she nor the owner of that post might want. Altogether, most participants seemed to perceive suggested posts as an unwanted pressure that forced their social networking and interactions with strangers.

4 DISCUSSION: RECONSIDERING USER AGENCY IN SOCIAL-MEDIA-SUPPORTED SOCIAL INTERACTIONS

The purpose of the "Suggested Posts" feature on Instagram is known to be "to make the feed the best place to share and connect with the people and interests that matter most to a user" [8]. Indeed, suggested posts were perceived by a few as a new opportunity

for networking in some respects. At the same time, however, we also found that this feature undermined most participants' sense of agency, i.e. the feeling of control over actions and their consequences [19], in their social interactions. While many prior works [2, 6, 15] have discussed the importance of supporting user agency in terms of their relationships with algorithms of social feeds (e.g. capability that the user is aware of and control the algorithms), our study particularly focuses on how recommender systems should be designed in the direction of supporting user agency of social interaction with other users, the core benefit of using social media.

Firstly, systems should support **users' sense of agency for deciding whom to socialize with and how much to socialize**. To address this, a few designs such as "Close Friends" of Instagram [16] or "Circles" of Google Currents [10] have been attempted in terms of managing friends groups on social media. However, although this issue can be also important when getting to know new users, current designs of "Suggested Posts" seem to often neglect it. For example, many participants in our study perceived suggested posts as a recommendation of strangers, which often forced networking without considering their sense of social distance towards strangers. In this regard, designers may refer to the social penetration theory [1], a theory that describes how people want gradual exchanges from the public self to the private self when forming new relationships with others. A user then, for example, can be allowed to organize posts into different layers of the information under his or her control, allowing the user to decide which layers of his or her personal information can be shared with recommended users with different social distances.

Also, considering that social media users actively post a variety of personal information such as tastes and lifestyles and that our study participants worried about the possibility that recommender systems arbitrarily expose those posts to random, unintended audiences as a serious threat, supporting **users' sense of agency for self-disclosure** should be considered more seriously than in systems of other domains. This may be mandatory rather than optional, as user agency for self-disclosure relates to the privacy issue frequently raised in the social-media-related research domain [3, 14, 24]. As Westin stated [23], privacy is *"the claim of individuals to determine for themselves when, how, and to what extent information about them is communicated to others"*. To address this, the system can provide users a channel for delicate control over the audience of reactions to suggested posts, for example. The system can also notify users before their posts appear as suggested posts and request the user's explicit consent for this.

5 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

In this paper, we investigated user experiences of the "Suggested Posts" feature through the lens of social networking and interactions. Our findings revealed various user perceptions towards suggested posts, based on which we discussed how suggested posts have been undermining users' sense of agency in their social interactions. Our study has several limitations. First, our study builds on a single social media platform, Instagram. For example, Facebook is used based on actual friends in many cases, and Twitter has relatively strong anonymity. Conducting future work on such platforms might reveal different shapes of users' social interaction

and perceptions of suggested posts. Second, although our study with participants in their 20s offered an initial contribution, further study with a generous age group is needed. Depending on user age, social interaction patterns and understanding of system-driven recommendations may differ. Third, we conducted this study in a single country. As social norms and dynamics are culturally sensitive, it may be meaningful to explore experiences of recommender systems in social media with users from diverse cultural backgrounds. We hope that this study inspires further studies on how to design recommender systems in a way that respects users in social media.

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